

- The Parallax Setup Runbook
 - PART 0 — Before you open Substack (2 min)
 - Decisions already locked
 - What you need ready on your desktop
 - PART 1 — Copy Bank (all strings, copy-paste ready)
 - 1.1 — Tagline (likely ≤ 80 chars; SEO-safe)
 - 1.2 — Short description / SEO description (~150 chars)
 - 1.3 — Long publication description (for the About page / Discover listing)
 - 1.4 — About page (the reader-facing decision page)
 - 1.5 — Author bio (short — appears on author page, comments, etc.)
 - 1.6 — Welcome email (auto-sends when someone subscribes)
 - 1.7 — Subscribe modal / CTA copy
 - 1.8 — Section descriptions
 - PART 2 — Execution (the navigation walkthrough)
 - PHASE A — Core publication identity (10 min)
 - PHASE B — About page + welcome email (15 min)
 - PHASE C — Sections (5 min)
 - PHASE D — Discovery + Notes setup (5 min)
 - PHASE E — Navigation, pinning, visual check (5 min)
 - PHASE F — The existing post (decide now)
 - PART 3 — Ship checklist (do NOT publish Edition 01 until all are )
 - PART 4 — First-week posting cadence (for reference)
 - Things I was less certain about (flag for verification)

The Parallax Setup Runbook

Goal: Convert your existing personal Substack into Parallax — configured, on-voice, and ready to post. **Time:** 45-60 minutes, done once. **Mode:** Free tier only (paid comes later).

Status of UI references: Substack moves settings around. I'll describe by function; if a menu name is slightly different, look for the closest match.

PART 0 — Before you open Substack (2 min)

Decisions already locked

- **Publication name:** Parallax
- **URL slug:** `parallax` → `parallax.substack.com` (if available). If taken: `parallaxletter`, `readparallax`, or `parallaxedition`.
- **Tagline:** `For people who were never meant to fit in one box.`
- **Sections:** Two — `Editions` and `Prompt Packs`
- **Discovery categories:** Culture, Philosophy, Technology
- **Existing post:** You'll decide: delete, archive, or re-tag as Edition 00.

What you need ready on your desktop

- Profile picture (you said you have it)
- This doc open in a second tab

PART 1 — Copy Bank (all strings, copy-paste ready)

Every piece of copy you'll need below. Paste directly.

1.1 — Tagline (likely ≤ 80 chars; SEO-safe)

For people who were never meant to fit in one box.

1.2 — Short description / SEO description (~150 chars)

Essays on AI, psychology, and consciousness from the intersection of everything. Each edition pairs a thesis with a 15-minute AI prompt pack.

1.3 — Long publication description (for the About page / Discover listing)

If you've been told to niche down, pick a lane, or be less of yourself – this is the opposite of that advice.

Parallax is for people who see everything from more than one angle. Each edition pairs a thesis – on AI, psychology, consciousness, or the strange intersection of all three – with a 15-minute AI prompt pack that gives you a micro-transformation you can run yourself.

You read. You run the prompts. Something shifts.

Free. Weekly. Written by Farrice Cain.

1.4 — About page (the reader-facing decision page)

You have 47 browser tabs open right now.

Your bookshelf makes no sense to anyone else. Philosophy next to training protocols next to Dragon Ball Z next to some book about AI you haven't finished. You can hold a conversation about neuroscience and then segue into why a specific anime arc is a better mastery metaphor than anything you learned in business school.

Someone, at some point, told you to pick a lane.

You probably tried. It probably felt like wearing a costume.

Parallax is what you build when you stop pretending to be less than you are.

Every edition is a thesis from the intersection of everything – AI, psychology, consciousness, creative work, what it costs to be a whole person in a world that rewards fragments. Each one comes paired with a prompt pack: five AI prompts, engineered from 18 years of coaching psychology, that you run yourself in Claude or ChatGPT. 15 minutes. Not motivational. Functional. Something shifts.

This is for the people who see more than one angle. The ones who've been told their range is a liability when it's actually the most valuable thing they own.

Subscribe if you understood every word of that.

– Farrice Cain

1.5 — Author bio (short — appears on author page, comments, etc.)

18 years in human psychology, coaching, and personal transformation. I write Parallax — for people who see everything from more than one angle.

1.6 — Welcome email (auto-sends when someone subscribes)

Subject line:

You're in. Here's what happens next.

Body:

Glad you're here.

Parallax is a weekly newsletter for people who see everything from more than one angle. Here's the deal so you know what you're getting:

Every week you get an Edition — a thesis from the intersection of AI, psychology, consciousness, or whatever refuses to fit in one box.

Every Edition comes paired with a Prompt Pack. Five AI prompts, engineered from 18 years of coaching psychology, that you run in Claude or ChatGPT. 15 minutes. The order matters. Something shifts.

You don't need to read every word. You don't need to do every prompt pack. This isn't homework.

But if you want to start somewhere: [link to Edition 01 once published]. It's the piece that explains why Parallax exists, and it pairs with The Interest Audit — a prompt pack that reframes your too-many-interests as the asset they actually are.

One more thing. Hit reply and tell me: what did you stop talking about publicly because it didn't fit your "brand"?

I read every one.

— Farrice

1.7 — Subscribe modal / CTA copy

Substack's default subscribe modal usually works. If it lets you customize headline + subtext:

Headline:

Subscribe to Parallax

Subtext:

Weekly essays + AI prompt packs for people who see more than one angle.
Free.

1.8 — Section descriptions

Section 1 — Editions

Weekly theses from the intersection of AI, psychology, consciousness, and what it costs to be a whole person in a world that rewards fragments.

Section 2 — Prompt Packs

Five AI prompts, engineered from 18 years of coaching psychology. Run in 15 minutes. Something shifts.

PART 2 — Execution (the navigation walkthrough)

Substack's settings live under the **gear icon** (Settings) in your dashboard sidebar. All paths below start from the Substack dashboard after login.

PHASE A — Core publication identity (10 min)

A1. Rename the publication

- Dashboard → **Settings** (gear icon)
- Find **Basics** (usually top of the settings list)
- Field: **Publication name** → paste **Parallax**
- Field: **Tagline / Short description** → paste the tagline from §1.1
- Save

A2. Change the URL slug

- Still in **Settings** → **Basics**
- Field: **Subdomain / URL** (may be labeled "Publication URL" or "Custom URL")
- Try **parallax** first. If taken, try **parallaxletter**, **readparallax**, **parallaxedition**
- **Warning:** Changing the URL breaks any existing links to your current Substack. Since you have one post with (presumably) low reach, this is fine — but decide about that post first (see Phase F).
- Save

A3. Upload logo / avatar

- Still in **Settings** → **Basics** (or a sub-tab labeled **Branding / Design**)
- Upload your profile picture as the publication logo
- If there's a separate "Publication image" or cover image field, upload the same one for now
- Save

A4. Set the SEO description

- In **Settings**, find **Publication details** or **SEO** (sometimes nested under "Basics" or "Advanced")
- Field: **Description / SEO description** → paste §1.2
- Save

★ Insight — Why the tagline line matters more than you think

———— Substack's homepage, the Discover algorithm, and every "recommended publication" card all lead with your tagline. It's the single piece of copy a stranger uses to decide whether to click. "For people who were never meant to fit in one box" invites self-

recognition — it's a filter, not a description. People who aren't your audience scroll past; people who are stop cold. That's the correct function of a tagline at this stage.

PHASE B — About page + welcome email (15 min)

B1. About page

- Dashboard sidebar → **Pages** (or look for **Customize pages** / **About page** inside Settings)
- Open the **About** page
- Replace default content with §1.4 (the reader-as-protagonist About copy)
- If there's a separate "Publication bio" on the same page, use §1.3
- Save / Publish the page

B2. Author bio (your personal profile, separate from publication)

- Top-right → click your avatar → **Profile** or **My account** → **Edit profile**
- Field: **Bio / About me** → paste §1.5
- Upload the same profile picture if it's not already on your personal profile
- Save

B3. Welcome email

- Settings → look for **Welcome email** or **Emails** or **Subscriber onboarding**
 - There's typically a toggle like "Send welcome email to new subscribers" — turn it ON if it isn't
 - **Subject line** → paste from §1.6
 - **Body** → paste the welcome email body from §1.6
 - **Important:** Where §1.6 says **[link to Edition 01 once published]**, either (a) leave it as placeholder and update after you publish Edition 01, or (b) temporarily change that paragraph to: *"New editions drop weekly. Your first one lands Monday."*
 - Save
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PHASE C — Sections (5 min)

Sections let you separate Editions from Prompt Packs on your homepage and in subscriber email preferences.

C1. Create the two sections

- Settings → **Sections** (if you don't see Sections, it may be under **Publication setup** or **Advanced**)
- Click **Add section / New section**
- Section 1:
 - Name: **Editions**
 - Description: paste §1.8 Editions
 - Publishing settings: Email + web (default)
- Section 2:
 - Name: **Prompt Packs**
 - Description: paste §1.8 Prompt Packs
 - Publishing settings: Email + web (default)

C2. (Optional) Set Editions as default Some Substack versions let you pick a default section new posts land in. If yours does, set default = **Editions**. You can always override per post.

PHASE D — Discovery + Notes setup (5 min)

D1. Discovery categories

- Settings → **Discover / Publication categories / Topics**
- Select up to 3: **Culture, Philosophy, Technology**
- If those exact categories don't exist, closest matches are: Lifestyle, Self-Improvement, Tech/AI, Writing
- Save

D2. Recommendations (partial setup now, expand later)

- Settings → **Recommendations**
- Leave blank for now. This is a mutual-ask system — after you publish Edition 01, you'll reach out to 5-10 similar-angle writers (Jun Yuh, Lulu Cheng Meservey types)

and recommend each other. Flag this as a post-launch task.

D3. Start a Substack Note today

- Dashboard → **Notes** tab (top nav, looks like a social feed)
- Post your first Note: a 2-3 line teaser of the manifesto. Draft:

I paid a business coach \$14K to tell me to niche down.
Two years later I figured out he was wrong about everything.
Edition 01 of Parallax drops Monday.

- Notes is 2026's primary Substack discovery surface — your content gets shown to non-subscribers in a way emails never will. Post one Note per week minimum.

PHASE E — Navigation, pinning, visual check (5 min)

E1. Pin the manifesto (after you publish Edition 01)

- On your homepage view, click the ⋮ menu on Edition 01
- Select **Pin to top / Feature on homepage**
- This becomes your hero — the first thing every visitor sees

E2. Remove clutter

- Go to your homepage as a logged-out visitor would see it (open an incognito window → parallax.substack.com)
- Check: is there a Leaderboard, Chat tab, or other default element that dilutes focus?
- Back in Settings → look for **Homepage / Layout / Navigation** options and hide anything that isn't: Home, About, Subscribe button
- For now, keep it minimal. You can enable Chat, Podcast, etc. later if you use them.

E3. Final visual sanity check Open three URLs in incognito and confirm:

- parallax.substack.com — pinned post visible, About link in nav, subscribe button prominent
- parallax.substack.com/about — the \$1.4 copy renders, no broken images

- Subscribe flow — click Subscribe from the homepage, enter a test email you can access, check: welcome email arrives, subject and body match §1.6

PHASE F — The existing post (decide now)

You have one post from your personal Substack phase. Three options:

Option	When to pick	How
Delete	If the post doesn't reflect Parallax's voice or thesis	Post → ⋯ menu → Delete
Unpublish & draft	Keep it for personal reference, off public view	Post → ⋯ menu → Unpublish
Keep as "Edition 00"	If it's strong and on-theme — rename, re-tag, re-date	Edit post → update title, assign to Editions section, optionally backdate

Default recommendation: Unpublish it. Start Parallax's public archive clean with Edition 01 as the first thing anyone sees. You can always republish later.

PART 3 — Ship checklist (do NOT publish Edition 01 until all are)

Before hitting publish on Edition 01:

- ☐ Publication name is **Parallax** everywhere (homepage, About, email signature)
- ☐ Tagline is live and visible under the logo
- ☐ URL is **parallax.substack.com** (or your chosen alt)
- ☐ Logo / avatar shows on homepage and in email preview
- ☐ About page shows §1.4 copy — no lorem ipsum, no default text
- ☐ Welcome email is ON, subject and body match §1.6
- ☐ Sections **Editions** and **Prompt Packs** exist
- ☐ Discovery categories set (3 selected)
- ☐ At least one Note posted to start warming the feed
- ☐ Existing personal post handled (deleted / unpublished / relabeled)

- ☐ Test subscribed with a secondary email and received the welcome email

When all ten are , publish Edition 01.

PART 4 — First-week posting cadence (for reference)

After setup, the rhythm:

- **Mon:** Publish Edition 01 (Manifesto) — assign to **Editions** section
 - **Mon:** Publish Prompt Pack 01 (Interest Audit) — assign to **Prompt Packs** section, or embed at bottom of Edition 01. Your call per edition.
 - **Tue:** Post a Note that quotes one line from Edition 01 (the "cage with better lighting" line is gold)
 - **Thu:** Post a Note teasing Edition 02 (Anti-Hustle)
 - **Mon** (next week): Edition 02 drops
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Things I was less certain about (flag for verification)

- **Exact Substack menu labels:** Substack has shifted "Settings" sub-menus several times. If "Basics" is called something else, look for wherever publication name + tagline + logo live together.
- **Welcome email editor behavior:** Some Substack accounts edit the welcome email via Settings, others via a separate Emails section. Both paths work.
- **Character limit on tagline:** SEO best practice is ≤ 60 chars for the SEO title specifically; the display tagline may allow more but shorter performs better on Discover cards.
- **Sections default:** Whether you can set a default section for new posts depends on account age / tier. If the option isn't there, just tag each post manually on publish.

If anything in the UI looks different from what I described, take a screenshot and I'll help you adapt it in the moment.